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The politico-cultural roots of Bangladesh: remembering the language movement through memoirs and autobiographical narratives

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ABSTRACT

This paper explores the 1952 language movement in Bangladesh through the interdisciplinary lens of memory studies and Bangladesh studies. By analyzing memoirs of influential figures—Abul Mansur Ahmad, Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, Mohammad Toaha, Mirza Nurul Huda and Badruddin Umar—it examines the movement's goals, leadership, organizational strategies, tactics, and emotional resonance. The movement, which began in 1948 and culminated in the tragic events of 21 February 1952, laid the foundation for the eventual emergence of Bangladesh in 1971. It led to the constitutional recognition of Bangla as a state language and, later, global acknowledgment through UNESCO's 1999 declaration of International Mother Language Day. Beyond political milestones, the movement is remembered as a powerful sociocultural uprising rooted in personal sacrifices and collective identity. Narratives of memory—often considered essential for shaping identity—serve here as tools for reconstructing history from individual perspectives. While psychologists have traditionally focused on personal memory and historians on national memory, this study bridges both realms. It introduces a theoretical framework that links language politics, cultural identity, trauma and historical memory to offer a deeper understanding of the movement's enduring legacy.

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1. Introduction

The 1952 language movement remains a defining moment in the socio-political history of Bangladesh. Bengali, as a language, has long withstood pressures from dominant languages such as Sanskrit, Persian, Arabic, English and, later, Urdu. This linguistic struggle can be traced as far back as the 13th century, well before the political partitions of the 20th century (Alam, 1991). The 1971 Liberation War, which culminated in the independence of Bangladesh, was deeply rooted in this earlier movement for linguistic and cultural recognition. The movement drew contributions from a diverse group of actors—students, political leaders, journalists, writers and civil society organizations—each playing key roles at different phases. Bengali nationalism was visibly articulated through the language struggles of 1947–1948 and 1952.

The linguistic debate intensified in 1947, when Dr. Ziauddin Ahmed, Vice-Chancellor of Aligarh Muslim University, declared Urdu as the future state language of Pakistan. In a swift rebuttal, Dr. Muhammad Shahidullah, a renowned Bengali linguist and professor at the University of Dhaka, argued in the *Daily Azad* (19 July 1947) that Bengali should be the medium of instruction and administration in East Pakistan (Haq, 2006, February 21). This demand gained political traction with the formation of the *Gana Azadi League* that same month.

Muhammad Ali Jinnah later reinforced the state's linguistic agenda by asserting that Urdu alone should be the national language of Pakistan. This pronouncement met with strong opposition in East Pakistan, where demands for Bengali's recognition grew louder (Ahmed, 1979). Wolpert (1984) observed

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that Jinnah's speech in Dhaka was the most volatile and divisive issue in Pakistani politics. After Liaquat Ali Khan's assassination, Prime Minister Khawaja Nazimuddin echoed Jinnah's stance during a 1952 visit to Dhaka, inciting outrage. In response, the All-Parties Action Committee was formed on 31 January 1952. This coalition included the Awami League, Islamic Brotherhood, Tamaddun Majlis, Youth League and student bodies from Dhaka University and other institutions (Rashiduzzaman, 1970). The *Tamaddun Majlis*, founded on 1 September 1947, emerged as a leading platform advocating for Bengali as the state language, influenced by the East Pakistan Renaissance Society (Basu, 2023).

The tragic events of 21 February 1952—when police opened fire on unarmed student demonstrators—resulted in the deaths of Salam, Rafiq, Barkat, Jabbar and Shafiur. These killings marked a turning point, eventually leading to the formal recognition of Bengali as one of Pakistan's state languages. The massacre also catalyzed the collapse of the Muslim League in East Pakistan and bolstered support for regional political forces, culminating in the sweeping victory of the United Front in the 1954 elections. Their 21-point manifesto explicitly called for linguistic recognition and regional autonomy (Islam, 1992; Jahan, 1972; Sayeed, 1960, 1967; Zaheer, 1994).

Duara (1995) offers a systematic account of the relationship between nation-state, nationalism and the concept of linear history. He argues that many historians of nation-states have adopted linear, evolutionary and teleological interpretations of history and have written repressive, exclusionary, fragmented and incomplete accounts of history. Duara critically examines the concept of linear history, especially in the context of modern nation-building and colonial legacies. He claims that linear history is a modernist, Eurocentric construction that does not adequately represent the complexity of non-Western societies or their historical experiences.

Ranjit Guha advocated in favor of 'small voice of history' through his subaltern historical approach. He posited the subaltern histories that they had set out to write in opposition to the 'elitist' histories of the time, something he accused not just the colonialists of writing but also the nationalists and early Marxist historians (Hardiman, 2023). Said (1994) introduced the concept of 'contrapuntal reading' to uncover silenced or ideologically distorted narratives within nationalist literature. Scholars such as Umar (2019) have alleged that political manipulation has often distorted the historical account of the language movement. Linking the 1952 language movement with the broader trajectory of Bangladesh's independence requires academic scrutiny, considering the distinct ideological, cultural and political underpinnings of each phase. Essential questions persist: What structural and ideological conditions shaped the language movement? Was the foundation of Bengali nationalism secular or communal? What made the cultural imagination of East Bengal (now Bangladesh) so unique that it led to secession? While these questions remain outside the paper's scope, this study focuses on the movement's key goals, leadership, organizational structure and mobilization strategies.

Drawing on selected memoirs, this study argues that mainstream historiography has been dominated by top-down nationalist discourse, often overlooking grassroots experiences and traumas. One of the major contributions of this paper is its identification of Bangladesh studies as a contested site of competing narratives and counter-narratives. It underscores how memoirs and autobiographies serve as critical, though contested, platforms for articulating individual memories of the language movement. By contextualizing these personal accounts within broader political narratives, this study engages in a necessary inquiry into how individual memory shapes collective history.

This paper is organized into six sections. Section one introduces the topic with a broad overview. Section two presents a historical background to frame the analysis. Section three proposes a theoretical framework connecting identity, language, memory and culture. The study uses a number of local memoirs and autobiographical works as a way of discussing wider social, political, historical and theoretical questions. Section four presents the findings and discusses how the movement's goals, leadership, strategies and tactics were pursued amid challenges and fear. Section five outlines the study's limitations, implications and future research directions. The paper concludes in section six with some reflective observations.

2. Bengal partition, memories and history

The roots of British colonialism in Bengal trace back to the 1757 Battle of Plassey, which marked the emergence of the British East India Company as a dominant power. The wealth extracted from Bengal

subsequently fueled Britain's rise as a leader in the Industrial Revolution by 1760. Colonial authorities implemented the 1793 Permanent Settlement to ensure a stable revenue stream, introducing a rigid bureaucratic system that exacerbated poverty and recurrent famines over nearly two centuries of British rule (1757–1947). As part of a broader imperial strategy, the British administration fostered Hindu-Muslim divisions, effectively using a 'divide and rule' policy to sustain their control. Although Muslims constituted approximately 52% of Bengal's population, they held only about 5.7% of elected positions, reinforcing political marginalization and economic disparity vis-à-vis the more affluent Hindu community (Rafique, 2015; Serajuddin, 2010, 2024; Ahmed 1988).

Communal tensions were inflamed by several developments: the 1909 Morley-Minto Reforms introduced separate electorates, the 1919 Government of India Act added political complexities and the rise of the Muslim League under Jinnah challenged existing power structures. The anti-zamindar stance of the *Krishak Proja Party* further widened political fissures. The 1928 Nehru Report and the 1932 Communal Award contributed to the communal divide, while the 1935 Government of India Act expanded provincial autonomy, resulting in the formation of a Muslim-led cabinet in Bengal following the 1937 elections (Rahim, 1981; Rashiduzzaman, 2021; Rahim 2011). The relationships between Hindus and Muslims were studied from the lens of communal violence. Rahaman (2024) concentrates on the complex relationship between Hindus and Muslims, exploring issues of nostalgia, identity, property and hope, revealing the slow acceptance among displaced Bengali Hindus of the (im)possibility of return in the context of the 1946 Noakhali riot. His analysis reveals the fact that the relations between the 'two groups were more complex than simple enmity' (Rahaman, 2024, p. 1608). Gupta (2019), in his *memoir*, reflects the experience of becoming uprooted—losing one's home, stability and sense of belonging during the partition of British India—presenting a nostalgic and emotional account of a Bengali life disrupted by 1947, focusing on loss, memory and the enduring search for belonging rather than just historical facts.

One of the most influential figures in this transitional period was A. K. Fazlul Huq, the leader of the *Krishak Proja Party*. Known for his commitment to both Muslim identity and Bengali regionalism. Fazlul Huq's political platform drew support across religious lines (Bhattacharjee, 2017). Aiyar (2008) emphasizes that Huq's brand of politics combined religious appeal with regional loyalty, creating a hybrid form of identity politics. His educational and socioeconomic reforms contributed to the emergence of a new Muslim intelligentsia in Bengal—comprising writers, thinkers and professionals—who would later play key roles in the region's political transformation (De, 2014; Sanaullah, 1995; Rahman, 2011).

Muhammad Ali Jinnah, as head of the Muslim League, was instrumental in promoting the two-nation theory, formally adopted through the Lahore Resolution in March 1940 (Jalal, 1985). In his speech preceding the resolution, Jinnah articulated a vision of irreconcilable cultural and civilizational differences between Hindus and Muslims. He argued that their distinct historical inspirations, social customs and values made a unified national identity impossible. As Jinnah said,

It is extremely difficult to appreciate why our Hindu friends fail to understand the real nature of Islam and Hinduism. They are not religions in the strict sense of the word, but are in fact different and distinct social order, and it is a dream to that the Hindus and Muslims can evolve a common nationality.... They neither intermarry, nor interline together and, indeed they belong to two different civilizations which are based mainly on conflicting ideas and conceptions. Their aspects on life and of life are different. It is quite clear that Hindus and Mussalmans derive their inspirations from different sources of history. They have different epics, their heroes are different, and their episodes. Very often, the Hero of one is a foe of the other and likewise their victories and defeats overlap. To yoke together two such nations under a single state, one as a numerical minority and the other as a majority, must lead to growing discontent and final destruction of any fabric that may be so built up for the government of such a state. (cited in Sayeed, 1967, p. 40)

Earlier still, Sir Syed Ahmad Khan (1817–1898) laid the intellectual groundwork for Muslim political consciousness under colonial rule. Through both scholarly and journalistic writings, he addressed complex interactions between Hindus, Muslims and the British (Kidwai, 2021; Shahriar, 2024). The culmination of these developments was the 1947 Partition, which led to the creation of India and Pakistan—and one of the largest human displacements of the 20th century. Approximately two million people perished and over 15 million were displaced during the partition. Millions became refugees and tens of thousands of women and girls were subjected to abduction and violence (Chatterji, 2011; Haq, 2022; Sehgal, 2022). The boundaries of the new states were hastily drawn by Cyril Radcliffe, a British lawyer unfamiliar with

the region, which only compounded the human toll. Butalia (2000) therefore claims that the official narrative of the Partition of India in 1947 is incomplete and that the human suffering, particularly of women, has been largely ignored or silenced.

Despite the trauma of partition, it inadvertently accelerated the emergence of a Bengali Muslim middle class, which played a crucial role in shaping the eventual independence movement (Ahmed, 2020; Amin, 2023; Uddin, 2016). Scholars like Fedtke (2023) argue that the partition served as a precursor to the 1971 Liberation War. Mukhopadhyay (2024) further contends that partition's memory remains a living, generational experience—its effects are enduring, not confined to 1947. These 'entangled memories' connect to identity, trauma and displacement in complex ways (Clini et al., 2024). Among the memoirs offering vital insight into this experience are *The Autobiography of an Unknown Indian* by Chaudhuri (2018) and *Amar Dekha Rajnir Ponchash Bochor* by Ahmad (2023). Likewise, Chatterji's (2023) *Shadows at Noon* and Thapar's (2026) *Just Being* integrate personal recollections with South Asian historical analysis, contributing to a deeper understanding of how memory shapes postcolonial identities.

I would like to situate this study within both memory studies and Bangladesh studies as complementary scholarly frameworks. Memory studies enable an analysis of how personal narratives—such as those of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman and Badruddin Umar—construct, contest and reinterpret the past through selective and politically inflected recollection. At the same time, Bangladesh studies provides the historical and intellectual context necessary to situate these narratives within broader processes of nationalism, state formation and historiographical debate.

As Iqbal (2014) argues, Bangladesh studies has emerged as a dynamic and expanding field, continually enriched by new contributions that revisit and reinterpret the region's past. Placing this work within that evolving field underscores how memoirs and competing historical accounts are not merely descriptive but actively participate in shaping the intellectual landscape of Bangladesh studies.

Bangladesh studies is currently experiencing a critical, transformative phase, shifting from a conventional, nation-building focus to a more critical, diasporic and interdisciplinary field. Key trends include the scrutiny of historical narratives, the emergence of diaspora-led critical studies and a push for academic freedom, amidst challenges from political constraints. In fact, Bangladesh studies as a field is a relative newcomer in Western academia. The American Institute for Bangladesh Studies (AIBS) was founded in 1989, as opposed to the American Institute for Indian Studies in 1961 and the American Institute for Pakistan Studies in 1973.

A significant milestone is that the *Journal of Bangladesh Studies* (JBS) was first published in 1999 by Bangladesh Development Initiative (BDI), a non-profit professional association of Bangladeshi academics and researchers in the US and the Subir and Malini Chowdhury Center for Bangladesh Studies was established in 2014 at the University of California, Berkeley (Paul, 2025).

Chowdhury's (2021 documentary) entitled *Their War' - Women in 1971 Liberation War* depicts the untold stories of Bangladeshi women who suffered during the 1971 Liberation War. The film highlights their roles as survivors of sexual violence, victims of atrocities and their struggle for justice, focusing on the systemic violence of the war. Chowdhury's work features powerful interviews and personal accounts, aiming to bring the voices of rural women into the mainstream understanding of the war (Chowdhury, 2022). Women's experiences of trauma and gendered violence during the 1971 war are reflected in their memoirs and novels as well (Iqbal, 2026). In the areas of Bangladesh studies, for instances, Riaz (2016) analyzes Bangladesh's post-1971 political trajectory through the interplay of democratization, identity politics and governance, while Van Schendel's (2005) ethnographic work examines the dynamics of the Bengal borderland, and Hasan (2024) traces the intellectual origins shaping the making of Bangladesh.

3. Identity politics, language movement and memory studies: a theoretical framework

History is not merely a chronology of events; it reflects the collective memory and actions of societies. Mukhopadhyay (2025) argues that history is shaped by those shared memories and acts of remembering. Individual memory, although shaped by personal experience, gains coherence through collective interpretations. Maurice Halbwachs' concept of collective memory provides a theoretical foundation for understanding how societies sustain their values and adapt to change. Such memory is socially constructed, often anchored in physical or symbolic space monuments, memorials, flags, or even names of historical figures

(Ogino, 2015). Nora (1989) made a distinction between history and memory, suggesting that memory is emotionally embedded and fluid, while history seeks structured documentation. The study of popular memory is necessarily relational and therefore Sarkar (2006) argues that memories are not simply sources of hitherto unknown information, but 'problematic sites of query in themselves' that require critical scrutiny. Memory studies, an emerging field, spans multiple disciplines—history, political science psychology, sociology, international relations, neuroscience and literature among them (Dubey, 2021; Roediger & Wertsch, 2008). The field seeks to understand how societies remember, forget, or silence parts of their past. Collective memory is not static but influenced by changing political, cultural and technological contexts.

Memory and identity are closely intertwined. As Du and Cui (2022) note in their analysis of Nobel Laureate Abdulrazak Gurnah's work, memory not only documents trauma and displacement but also shapes identity in diasporic and postcolonial contexts. His literary narratives highlight how memory can challenge dominant discourses and amplify marginalized perspectives. Gurnah's *Memory of Departure*, set in the years immediately after Tanzania's independence in 1961, disrupts normative gender binaries that give false assurance of characters being either male or female. The novel insists that the reader sees subjectivity and subjection as twin vectors to explain how power extends to characters' bodies (Kaigai, 2014). Correia and Caetano (2024) argue that memory, especially in autobiographical contexts, is shaped by time, stimuli and social context—further reinforcing its link to evolving identity.

Figure 1 proposes a theoretical framework connecting familial traditions, socio-economic status, religion and political ideology—all factors influencing identity construction. Language, as a cultural cornerstone, becomes a defining element in this identity-making process. Rahman (2000) and Haque (1973) emphasized the socioeconomic foundations of the language movement, arguing that the demand for linguistic rights was inherently linked to the growing aspirations for autonomy, justice and self-determination. Through this lens, the language movement can be understood not merely as a cultural or linguistic demand, but as part of a broader identity politics rooted in historical memory and collective grievance.

Memoirs and autobiographies offer invaluable insights into the past, especially when the authors have either directly participated in the events they describe or have acquired information from primary witnesses. These first-person narratives often present information absent from formal historical records and serve as essential tools for reconstructing events, particularly for social historians. Within the social, political and cultural spheres, memory plays a vital role in shaping individual and collective identity. Intergenerational transmission of memory occurs through a network of texts, photographs, films, archives, monuments and rituals—forming what scholars term the 'politics of memory' (Geetha, 2020; Malinova, 2021). The use of such primary sources—memoirs, letters and diaries—enriches historical inquiry by capturing the lived realities of those who experienced key events (Liftig, 2021).

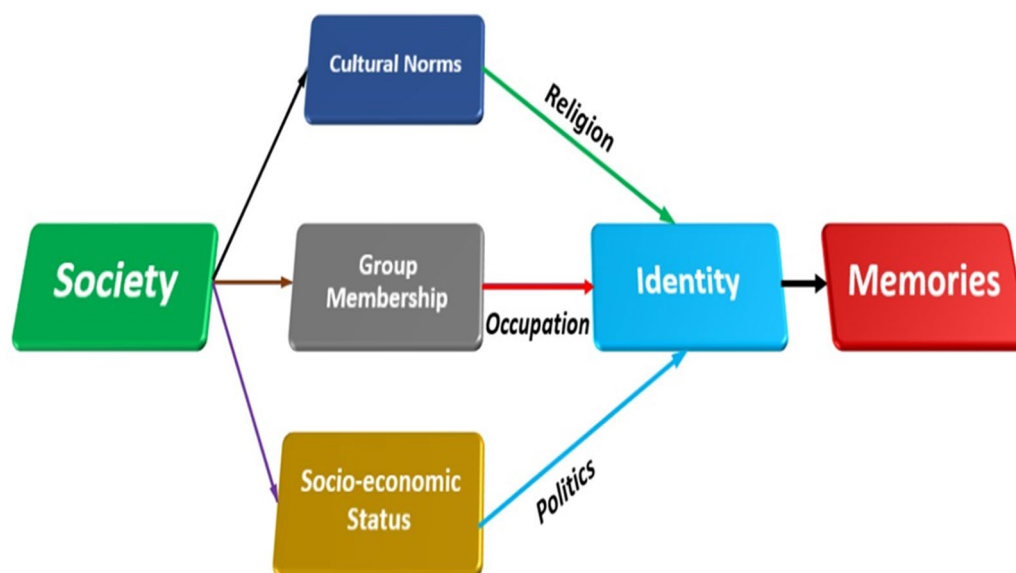


Figure 1. The framework on cultural norms, identity politics and memory studies (Source: Author's own elaboration).

Stanley and De Brigard (2019) put an emphasis on the importance of morality in memory studies. They note that most people believe they are morally good, and this belief plays an integral role in constructions of personal identity. Memory is often seen as a moral correction. As they argue:

Memory retrieval and event reconstruction might be used in advantageous ways to create a morally good sense of self in the present. Personal past events can also be woven into a life story in a way that helps to maintain a favorable view of the current self: Our past failures, improprieties, and shortcomings can be attributed to a distant, dissimilar past self who has changed considerably over time for the better. (Stanley & De Brigard, 2019, p. 388)

Poole (2008) emphasizes that memory is not merely cognitive but also normative, carrying moral responsibilities in transmitting historical consciousness. It is central to the reconstruction of national identity and historical justice (Booth, 2006). Autobiographical memory, characterized by self-referential and event-specific recollection, underscores personal experience as an epistemological foundation (Conway, 1987). The global rise in memoir and autobiography publications, referred to as the 'memoir boom', reflects growing interest in individual perspectives on collective history (Fass, 2006). According to Sierp (2021), four major factors have contributed to the expansion of memory studies as a field:

- The trauma and memory legacy of Holocaust survivors.
- The end of the Cold War and the search for redefined identities.
- The process of decolonization and postcolonial inquiry.
- Rapid developments in media and digital technologies.

Despite its expanding scope, memory studies lack unified definitions or disciplinary boundaries. Scholars like Dutceac Segesten and Wüstenberg (2017) and Odak et al. (2023) describe the field as still developing, with evolving theoretical and methodological paradigms.

4. Analysis of the language movement: Findings & discussion

The state of the United Pakistan was geographically absurd, with its eastern and western wings separated by over 1000 miles. This spatial separation was mirrored by profound cultural, linguistic and political divisions. Among these, the language issue became one of the most potent drivers of dissent and resistance in East Pakistan. Soon after the independence of 1947, the Pakistani leaders spent almost nine years (1947–1956) to frame their first constitution. Professor G. W. Choudhury, a political scientist and ardent analyst of the politics of United Pakistan observed as follows:

The cultural and linguistic differences are more significant. Geographical separation finds expression in other differences—those of racial complexion, language, habits of life, and culture. The people of the western region speak different languages—Punjabi, Pushtu, Sindi, Baluchi; yet most of them look upon Urdu as their common heritage. In East Pakistan Bengali is the cherished language. West Pakistan is predominantly Muslim has important non-Muslim minorities. These differences were exploited by a group of disgruntled politicians, in both East and West Pakistan, who encouraged provincialism and did considerable harm to feelings of national unity. They found in the delay in constitution-making an excellent opportunity for endeavors to disrupt the state. (Choudhury, 1969, p. 68).

On 25 February 1948, Dharendra Nath Dutta, a Congress member of Pakistan's Constituent Assembly, made a passionate appeal to recognize Bengali as a state language. He emphasized,

Out of sixty-nine million people in Pakistan, forty-four million speak Bengali... the state language should reflect the language spoken by the majority, and I believe Bengali is the lingua franca of our state. (cited in Haq, February 21, 2006)

However, this appeal was dismissed by Prime Minister Liaquat Ali Khan, who insisted that Urdu—symbolic of Muslim identity across South Asia—must be the sole national language of Pakistan.

Akanda (2013) contends that the language movement, which began as a cultural struggle for linguistic recognition, gradually transformed into a political movement demanding regional autonomy. The deaths of Jinnah in 1948 and Liaquat in 1951 created a leadership vacuum, filled by Khwaja Nazimuddin, who reinforced the state's pro-Urdu stance. On 26 January 1952, during a public speech in Paltan Maidan,

Table 1. Profiles of key memoirists based on professional and political backgrounds.

Memoirists	Memoirs/ autobiographies	Language of the memoirs	Language movement specific role	Education	Profession	Class orientation
Ahmad (2023)	<i>Amar Dekha Rajnir</i> <i>Ponchash Bochor</i> <i>Smitikotha</i>	In Bengali	Political activist and writer of the 21-point of the United Front of 1954 election A member of the Sarbadaliya Rashtrabhasa Sangram Committee formed on 30 January 1952	B.A.	Journalist, politician, lawyer and writer Leftist politician & activist	Middle class Middle Class
Toaha (2022)		In Bengali				
Huda (2021)	<i>My Seven Decades' Journey Through British India, Pakistan and Bangladesh</i>	In English	Language movement witness	Ph.D. in economics	Dhaka University's economics professor, finance minister and governor of East Pakistan	Middle class
Umar (2021)	<i>Amar Jibon</i>	In Bengali	Language movement historian and political activist	M.A. in philosophy	Historian, politician and writer	Middle class
Rahman (2013)	<i>Unfinished Memoirs</i>	In English	Language movement observer and political leader	B.A.	Member of the electoral alliance –United Front- formed in 1954	Middle class

Source: Own elaboration.

Dhaka, he reiterated that Urdu would remain Pakistan's only state language—retracting earlier conciliatory promises. The speech provoked intense backlash, especially among university students.

The student-led protests escalated on 21 February 1952, when demonstrators defied Section 144, a ban on public gatherings. The resulting police firing claimed several lives. These martyrs galvanized the movement, which quickly gained popular support across rural and urban Bengal. As Jahan (1972) noted, the rural connection was significant because 'the large majority of Bengali students came from these areas' (Jahan, 1972, p. 44).

Tamaddun Majlish, a cultural organization founded on 2 September 1947 by physicist Abul Kashem and students from Dhaka University, played a key role in the intellectual foundation of the movement. The organization's 1947 booklet, *Pakistaner Rashtra Bhasha: Bangla Na Urdu?* (The State Language of Pakistan: Bengali or Urdu?), argued that Bengali should serve as the language of education, administration and mass communication in East Pakistan. The document also proposed that both Bengali and Urdu should be recognized at the federal level (Kabir, 1987). While originally formed to counter the spread of communism and secularism, Tamaddun Majlish soon became the ideological bedrock of the language movement (Maniruzzaman, 2003).

The autobiographical reflections of prominent movement-era figures provide crucial insights into this period. Table 1 illustrates how the memoirists reflect a politically aware, educated Muslim middle class in East Pakistan. This demographic, shaped by colonial-era developments such as the founding of Dhaka University in 1921, was pivotal in articulating and leading the language movement. The memories and life writings are the representatives work of the Muslim authors and their empowerment that created an educated Muslim middle class in East Bengal/East Pakistan culminating in independent Bangladesh. These five autobiographies that blend life writing and history deserve scholarly attention because of the ways they allow us to examine our access to both individual and collective pasts (Aurell & Davis, 2019). The emergence of the Bengali Muslim Middle class can be traced back to the era of British colonialism. The establishment of the Dhaka University in 1921 was an impetus to the growth of the newly educated Muslim middle class. As Karim (1976, 1984) pointed out, British colonial rule fostered the rise of a new middle class through its economic, administrative and educational reforms. Members of this emerging intelligentsia included influential leaders such as A. K. Fazlul Huq, H. S. Suhrawardy, Maulana Bhashani and Sheikh Mujibur Rahman (Murshid, 2022).

The replacement of Persian with English as the official language in 1835 contributed significantly to the growth of a class of English-educated Bengalis. This group later assumed leadership roles in anti-colonial and democratic movements (Bhuiyan, 2013). The emergence of Bangladesh, however, cannot be fully explained through economic disparities alone. Hashmi (2022) therefore asserts that the divide between East and West Pakistan was primarily psychological and cultural, shaped by decades of disrespect and denial of recognition. From the language movement of 1948 to the refusal to honor the 1970 election results, East Pakistan's struggle was fundamentally about political identity and cultural dignity.

4.1. *Abul Mansur Ahmad (1898–1979)*

Abul Mansur Ahmad's autobiographical work *Amar Dekha Rajnitir Ponchash Bochor* stands as a crucial primary source for understanding the origins, leadership and organizational facets of the language movement. Born in Dhanikhola village of Mymensingh in 1898, Ahmad experienced the 1905 Partition of Bengal as a child and was later actively engaged in the political affairs of both colonial Bengal and post-partition Pakistan. His contributions to the movement were manifested through both literary advocacy and political engagement. A firm believer in secularism, Ahmad emphasized the separation of religion from politics, once asserting, 'Let religion begin where politics ends; the two must not meet' (cited in Sayeed, 1967, p. 187).

As the editor of the Calcutta-based *Ittehad* during 1946–1948, Ahmad strongly advocated for the Bengali language. He played a pivotal role in drafting the 21-point manifesto of the United Front, which secured a decisive victory in the 1954 provincial elections (Amin, 2015). Earlier, in 1942, the East Pakistan Renaissance Society had been formed through the efforts of Abul Kalam Shamsuddin and Mujibur

Rahman Khan, emphasizing mutual recognition of rights in the quest for Pakistan. Ahmad's memoir offers profound reflections on his ministerial roles—both as a regional minister for nine days and later as a federal minister from September 1956 to October 1958.

In his 1944 speech at the East Pakistan Renaissance Society in Calcutta, Ahmad underscored the distinct cultural identity of Bengali Muslims. Critiquing Rabindranath Tagore's vision, he stated,

The Muslims of Bengal ... cannot be great by imitating Rabindranath. They will have to develop their own identity on the basis of their own culture. In the world of Visva-Bharati of the world-poet Rabindranath, so many times has the joyous Mother come and departed, but never for a day in the sky of that world did the moon of Eid and Muharram [Muslim holy days] appear ... it is the harsh truth. (cited in Quayum, 2025, p. 3)

Abul Mansur Ahmad played a significant role in advancing Muslim identity in Bengal through his involvement in politics, journalism, and literature. During the late colonial period and the early years of Pakistan, he sought to improve the political, educational, and economic conditions of Bengali Muslims, a community that had long experienced social and economic marginalization. He also advocated a conception of identity that reconciled religious and cultural affiliations, arguing that Bengali Muslims could preserve their Islamic faith while simultaneously embracing their Bengali linguistic and cultural heritage. This position challenged attempts to define Muslim identity solely in religious terms and highlighted the distinct cultural character of Bengali Muslims.

In addition to his cultural and political advocacy, Ahmad was deeply concerned with the socioeconomic conditions of the Muslim peasantry, many of whom were poor farmers subject to exploitation by large landowners. He supported agrarian reforms aimed at reducing rural inequalities and improving the livelihoods of disadvantaged communities. For Ahmad, the advancement of Bengali Muslims depended not only on the preservation of religious identity but also on broader processes of social and economic development. His writings and political activities therefore linked the crucial questions of Muslim identity with the issues of education, economic justice, and political empowerment, thereby establishing him as an influential voice in shaping modern Bengali Muslim consciousness (Amin, 1987, 2011).

In fact, Abul Mansur Ahmad was a spokesman for the ideal of Bengali-Muslim autonomy (Sartori, 2007). In other words, Abul Mansur Ahmad's memoir blends his individual life with broader historical movements. His narrative contributes to what scholars call collective memory—how a nation or group remembers its past. His perspective helps construct a specifically Bengali Muslim political memory of events like the late colonial period and partition.

4.2. Sheikh Mujibur Rahman (1920–1975)

Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, born in 1920, completed his undergraduate studies at Calcutta University and earned a law degree from Dhaka University. As a founding member of the Awami League in 1949, he played a central role in the party's sweeping victory in the 1970 elections. His involvement in the early phase of the language movement is documented in *The Unfinished Memoirs*, where he recalled how, in February 1948, the Pakistan Constituent Assembly debated Urdu as the sole national language, sidelining Bengali despite its majority speakers. Together with Tamaddun Majlish and the East Pakistan Muslim Students' League, Mujib opposed this decision and advocated for equal recognition of Bengali (Mujib, 2013, p. 97).

Mujib viewed the language movement as a precursor to the broader struggle for self-rule. However, some scholars like Umar (2017) contend that Mujib's actual role during the critical events of 21 February 1952—when he was imprisoned—was limited.

A few points emerge from *The Unfinished Memoirs* by Sheikh Mujibur Rahman (2013). First, it is not just recollection, it's a self-positioning narrative. He frames himself as an early and consistent defender of Bengali language rights.

Second, Mujib's interpretation of the language movement as a 'precursor to self-rule' reflects retrospective understanding after 1971. The language movement is framed as the ideological starting point of Bengali nationalism. Mujib's account reinforces the dominant narrative that language controversy led to the autonomy movement. The movement for regional autonomy eventually gave birth to Bangladesh.

Third, the mention of Tamaddun Majlish and East Pakistan Muslim Students' League is important as these groups show how civil society and student activism were central to the language movement.

4.3. *Mohammad Toaha (1922–1987)*

A committed leftist and language activist, Mohammad Toaha played a significant role in the early stages of the language movement. He was a prominent student leader at the University of Dhaka. He was associated with progressive and leftist student organizations, including the East Pakistan Students Union and other underground communist-affiliated groups.

Toaha was instrumental in founding and supporting key organizations such as the East Pakistan Muslim Students' League, Tamaddun Majlish and Gana Azadi League. His memoir presents a critical analysis of misconceptions about the goals and leadership of the movement. He was involved in the formation of the All-Party State Language Action Committee. This committee played a pivotal role in organizing demonstrations, meetings and protests demanding recognition for the Bengali language.

Toaha highlighted the tensions between the Urdu-speaking population of Old Dhaka and the Bengali-speaking student activists. A rift was observed between the Urdu-Speaking people in Old Dhaka region and the Students of the Dhaka university. As Toaha noted,

To create a sense of confusion between the Urdu-speaking inhabitants of the Old Dhaka city and the Bengali-speaking students, Sir Nazimuddin intentionally worked for the creation of an atmosphere of animosity. The people living in the old Dhaka city became very ferocious upon those students and activists who were demanding Bangla as one of the state languages. Eventually, the angry mob demolished the office of the Tamaddin Majlish situated in the then Dewan Bazar Rail Crossing area. (Toaha, 2022, p. 107)

It is interesting to note that the people coming from the old Dhaka area warned that they will not hesitate to 'kill' the students for opposing the Urdu.¹

We can now connect how Toaha's narration appeals to memory studies by showing that it not just as a historical account, but as a constructed narrative of the past—one that reflects perspective, power and selective remembrance. First, let us think about who is remembering. Mohammad Toaha is not a neutral observer; he was a committed political actor in the Bengali language movement. In memory studies, this matters because personal memoirs are forms of subjective memory. They shape how events are later understood, often emphasizing certain actors (like leftist groups) while challenging dominant narratives that may sideline them.

Second, this text illustrates counter-memory. Official histories of the language movement often foreground mainstream political leaders or parties, but Toaha highlights the role of student activists and leftist organizations such as East Pakistan Students Union and Tamaddun Majlish. In memory studies, this is an attempt to recover marginalized voices and contest what is remembered collectively.

Third, his memoir shows how memory engages with conflict and identity formation. The tensions between Urdu-speaking residents and Bengali-speaking students—especially the portrayal of hostility in Old Dhaka—demonstrate how collective memories can construct 'us vs. them' narratives. The role attributed to Khawaja Nazimuddin in fostering division reflects how memory can assign blame and interpret motives, which may differ from other historical accounts. Fourth, Toaha is connected to sites of memory (*lieux de mémoire*). Places like Dhaka University and areas in Old Dhaka have become symbolic in memory—they are not just locations but carriers of historical meaning, associated with protest, violence and political awakening.

Finally, Toaha's memoir performs memory as interpretation, not just recollection. His 'critical analysis of misconceptions' shows that memory is active—it argues, revises and reshapes the past rather than simply recording it.

4.4. *Mirza Nurul Huda (1919–1991)*

An esteemed economist and long-time professor at Dhaka University, Mirza Nurul Huda documented in his memoirs the socio-political transformation of East Bengal. Born in a village near Tangail in 1919, Huda witnessed the unfolding of the language movement from an academic perspective. He reflected on the grief and resistance that followed the deaths of language martyrs such as Abdus Salam and Abul Barkat. Recalling the reaction, he stated, 'We held funeral prayers in absentia at S.M. Hall, as the bodies were

not released' (Huda, 2021, p. 84). Huda saw the movement as the first critical rupture in the foundation of the Pakistani state.

In his memoir, Huda provided an intriguing discussion about his 1948 controversial statement of Jinnah at the Curzon Hall of the University of Dhaka. Quoting a personal physician attending Jinnah, Huda came to learn Jinnah's self-realization on his role in the language movement. Jinnah said from his sick bed that he made two mistakes. The first was not recognizing Bengali as a state language. The second was not paying enough attention to the interests of East Pakistan.

We can note a few important analytical points from Mirza Nurul Huda's narratives on the language movement.

First, he is not just documenting events but reinterpreting them through hindsight, especially writing after the emergence of Bangladesh. The mention of martyrs like Abdus Salam and Abul Barkat is not just personal recollection—it contributes to Bangladesh's collective memory of sacrifice.

Second, he recalls some sites of memory such as Curzon Hall, S. M. Hall and the University of Dhaka. Sites of memory (*lieux de mémoire*) is a concept popularized by Pierre Nora, who refers to symbolic and material spots like monuments, museums, traditions, or places—that crystallize a community's shared heritage and identity (Nora, 1996).

Third, the grief described is analytically important. The inability to access the bodies and hold symbolic funerals reflects trauma and state repression, key themes in memory studies. Memory here is shaped by loss, absence and injustice, not just events.

Fourth, Huda did not hear Muhammad Ali Jinnah directly; he relies on a physician. This is an example of a layered memory, showing how narratives are constructed through intermediaries.

Finally, Huda is not directly quoting Muhammad Ali Jinnah but relaying something he 'came to learn' through a physician. This introduces layers: Jinnah → physician → Huda → readers. Each layer shapes the memory. From this perspective, the statement becomes less a fixed historical fact and more a circulating narrative that gains meaning through repetition and retelling. Huda's account can be seen as reading the past through the lens of later developments. By presenting Jinnah as regretful, the narrative aligns history with what later became widely accepted: that ignoring Bengali language rights was a major political mistake. We have observed in the theoretical section that Stanley and De Brigard (2019) explained memory in terms of moral correction. In memory studies, it is common to see historical figures reinterpreted in ways that resolve tensions. Here, Jinnah is remembered not just as a political leader, but as someone capable of self-criticism. This 'confession' softens his image and creates a sense of moral closure—almost as if history corrects itself through memory.

4.5. Badruddin Umar (1931–2025)

Although not an active participant, Badruddin Umar was a direct observer of the key developments surrounding the language movement. In *Amar Jibon*, he recalled the 'intense debates and activism' of the period (Umar, 2021, p. 307). His multi-volume work entitled, *Purbobanglar Bhasha Andolon o Tothkalin Rajniti* remains a seminal contribution to understanding the movement's history (Umar, 1972).

In his memoir, Umar documented how public observances shifted from March 11 (1949–1951) to 21 February post-1952. He elaborated on the role of Dhaka University's State Language Movement Committee and various pamphlets circulated to raise awareness. As editor of *Sainik* and contributor to *Duity*, Umar chronicled the rise of new political forces like the Purbo Pakistan Jubo League. Leaders such as Toaha, Abul Hashim, Oli Ahad and others played significant roles. Umar himself authored *Amader Bhasher Lorai* (Our Struggle for Language), which was publicly broadcast during protests. Umar further explained the socioeconomic and political ramifications of the February resistance. As he said,

For definite socioeconomic and political reasons, the revolt could neither be transformed into a social revolution nor it last longer than it actually did. But one thing is clear. Through the language movement, united resistance of the people of East Bengal against the exploitation of feudal, big bourgeois and imperialist agencies in general, and against the Pakistan government in particular, took a definite phase. (Umar, 1987, p. 10)

The memoirs of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman (2013) and Badruddin Umar (2021) foreground an important historiographical debate by demonstrating that history functions as a contested memory rather than an objective recounting of the past. In *The Unfinished Memoirs*, Mujib retrospectively frames his political trajectory as continuous and central, positioning his early involvement in the language movement as a precursor to Bangladesh's independence. This narrative reflects the selective and meaning-making nature of autobiographical memory.

In contrast, Badruddin Umar's interpretation serves as a form of counter-memory, challenging the dominance of Mujib's account by questioning the extent of his role during critical events such as February 1952. The coexistence of these perspectives illustrates that memory is not fixed but is instead constructed, contested and shaped by political and ideological positions. From a Bangladesh studies perspective, this debate reveals how national history is produced through struggles over representation and authority, where certain figures are elevated while alternative voices seek to reframe the narrative. In a nutshell, we note that Mujib's memory builds authority and national leadership whereas Umar's memory critiques and redistributes that authority.

4.6. Language movements and the emergence of Bangladesh

The language movement marked a pivotal moment in East Pakistan's resistance to the centralized power structure dominated by West Pakistan's civil-military oligarchy. The control of the economy and politics by a handful of business conglomerates—known as the 'Twenty-two Families' exacerbated existing grievances (Papanek, 1972).

The language issue was both a cultural and political battleground. For Awami League leaders, it symbolized the quest for regional autonomy. For leftist groups, it represented resistance against capitalist elites. February 21 became a powerful symbol of resistance, galvanizing city workers and the urban middle class (Islam, 2017; Rashiduzzaman, 2025).

Cultural alienation also played a role. As Choudhury (2014) notes, attempts to impose a uniform Islamic cultural identity led Bengali Muslims to identify more with their Bengali Hindu counterparts in West Bengal than with West Pakistan. The language movement had a kind of seductive appeal to the domestic as well as regional cultural forces in Pakistan. The language became an emotive issue in United Pakistan and as a result, the Indian government and intelligent forces got an ample opportunity to be involved in making use of the emotions of the Bengali population. In his book entitled, the *Last Days of United Pakistan*, Choudhury (2014) observes as follows:

Every attempt made by the Pakistan Government to foster a cultural uniformity based on Islamic culture in East Pakistan produced a sharp reaction, the Bengalis began to look more and more to West Bengal for cultural affinity and bonds. The Indians, who had not been happy about Jinnah's two-nation theory, gave encouragement and sympathy to the growing separatist movement in East Bengal. The Bengali Muslim intelligentsia were more at home with the Bengali Hindu in West Bengal than with their fellow countrymen from West Pakistan. Culturally, and perhaps psychologically, the country was divided long before the crisis of 1971. (p.12)

This cultural rift predated the 1971 crisis. The broader global context—decolonization, the Cold War and globalization—also influenced the formation of Bangladesh (Raghavan, 2013).

In recognition of the historic movement, UNESCO declared 21 February as International Mother Language Day in 1999. With over 50 ethnic communities speaking 41 mother tongues in Bangladesh, language preservation remains a crucial concern (Arif, 2023). Yet Bangladesh lacks a formal language policy—an area warranting further scholarly attention.

The declaration of International Mother Language Day by UNESCO in 1999 carries both symbolic and practical significance, especially when read in light of Bangladesh's linguistic reality. At a symbolic level, the day internationalizes the memory of the Bengali Language Movement. What began as a regional struggle for linguistic recognition is transformed into a global remembrance of language rights. In terms of memory studies, this shows how a local historical event becomes part of global collective memory, preserving the legacy of linguistic activism beyond national boundaries.

At the same time, observance highlights the ongoing relevance of linguistic diversity. With more than 50 ethnic communities and 41 mother tongues in Bangladesh, the issue is no longer just about Bengali

versus Urdu, but about protecting minority languages from marginalization and loss. International Mother Language Day thus shifts the focus from a single dominant language to a broader concern with multi-lingual inclusivity and cultural survival.

The mention that Bangladesh lacks a formal language policy adds another layer of significance. It suggests a gap between commemorative memory and institutional practice. While the country actively celebrates 21 February, the absence of a structured policy raises questions about how effectively linguistic diversity is being preserved. From a scholarly perspective, this opens up space to examine how states remember versus how they act.

5. Limitations, implications and future research directions

The current analysis acknowledges the inherent subjectivity of memoirs and autobiographies. In Bangladesh, historical narratives are frequently contested, reshaped and politicized, often reflecting the interests of those in power. Competing versions of events are crafted for political agendas, and memoir literature has at times served to validate official state narratives (Kuromiya, 1985).

This study purposefully centers on selected memoirs—all authored by men. It is well recognized that men and women often view socio-political events through different lenses. Women, too, played instrumental roles in the language movement, although their contributions have received comparatively less attention. Notable female participants such as Dr. Halima Khatun, Dr. Sufia Khatun, Sufia Ibrahim, Fazilatunnessa, Rani Bhattachariya, Pratibha Mutsuddi, Sofia Khan, Zulekha, Nuri, Sara Taifur, Sufia Ahmed and Safia Khatun broke Section 144, confronted police barricades and participated in demonstrations on Dhaka University's campus. Several were arrested and harassed for their activism. While South Asian politics is often portrayed as male-dominated, both historical records and fictional narratives of Bangladesh's Liberation War reveal women's significant engagement (Fedtke, 2023). Their bottom-up voices and perspectives warrant further investigation, particularly through memoirs or personal narratives that may exist in lesser-known formats.

Several prominent male activists—such as Aatur Rahman Khan, Oli Ahad, Kamruddin Ahmed, Bashir Al Helal, Ahmed Rafique, Anisuzzaman, Serajul Islam Chowdhury, Mahbub Ul Alam Choudhury, Abdul Gafur, Abdul Gaffar Chowdhury, A. N. M. Gaziul Haque, Rezaul Haque Khondokhar, Ghulam Azam, Principal Ibrahim Khan and Haider Akbar Khan Rono—have contributed memoirs and reflections related to the language movement. Kamal (1997) has compiled interviews and documents that are valuable for future studies. As 21 February is now globally recognized as International Mother Language Day, scholars have an opportunity to broaden the scope of inquiry to include global ramifications and cross-cultural perspectives.

While Bangladesh's Liberation War has been extensively studied through memoirs (Azam, 2024), the language movement has yet to be systematically explored through the theoretical lens of memory studies. Future researchers could analyze how memoirs reflect authors' personal agency, linguistic activism and their contribution to shaping national identity. This line of inquiry would strengthen the linkage between personal memory and collective historical consciousness.

Further research could include doctoral or master's theses that would investigate the socio-political and cultural dimensions of the language movement using historical memoirs. The historiography of Bangladesh remains constrained by dominant nationalist narratives, particularly those centered around Sheikh Mujibur Rahman and his family. As Badruddin Umar pointed out in an interview with *Bangladesh Sangbad Sangstha* (BSS), much of the official history—especially that concerning 1971—remains contested. 'The true history of the 1971 Bangladesh War of Independence has not been written yet. What is written is the official commentary; 80 to 90 percent is false' (BSS News, 2024).

This concern echoes broader global trends in reevaluating nationalist historiography. For instance, Branigan's (2023) *Red Memory* provides a nuanced examination of the Cultural Revolution in China, shedding light on silenced narratives and the lingering psychological scars left by that era. Similarly, studies now recognize that intergenerational memory and reciprocal fear can fuel political violence and ethnonationalist conflict (Pamungkas & Permana, 2024). The trauma of the February 1952 killings inflicted long-lasting psychological wounds during the era of United Pakistan. Future interdisciplinary studies involving psychology, political science, sociology, history, linguistics and anthropology could offer deeper insights into the role of fear, identity and memory in shaping the trajectory toward Bangladesh's independence.

6. Conclusion

This paper aimed to examine the historical language movement in light of methodological innovations in memory studies while also advancing new theoretical perspectives. It contends that historians can draw on historiographical approaches to diversify their analyses of the past and employ alternative scholarly methodologies. In this paper, I mentioned two main approaches that gained traction in recent years. One is Professor Prasanjit Duara's (1995) theoretical argument that nationalistic narrative—a linear paradigm of understanding the past—neglects the other dynamics that contribute to historical studies. The straightforward nationalistic history with unilateral claims is unrealistic because modern nationalism itself is pluralistic, fungible and changing. Then, I tried to apply the tools of memory studies, including the allied methods and sources to understand who did what in the language movement. Both the approaches are groundbreaking. The paper proposes an innovative theoretical framework for examining the language movement through memoirs and autobiographical writings, thereby expanding the academic literature on this historic movement.

The historiography of Bangladesh remains a site of contested narratives and political tensions and the history of the language movement is no exception. Drawing on Prasenjit Duara's concept of linear history, this study challenges the assumption that history moves in a straight line of continuous progress or through a simple chain of cause-and-effect events. Instead, it highlights how the movement's history reflects complexities, contradictions, fears, overlaps and recurrences—more like a web, cycle, or spiral, rather than a straight path.

This study has argued that memoirs and autobiographies are valuable sources for uncovering overlooked grassroots perspectives. While early support for the language movement may have been limited, the events of February 1952 catalyzed broader participation and transformed it into a major socio-political movement. Rather than relying solely on official state histories, this work emphasizes the importance of alternative narratives, particularly those found in personal memoirs and autobiographies. The role of socio-cultural organizations like *Tamaddun Majlish* and the active involvement of students were instrumental in the movement's evolution. Given its complexity, the history of the language movement demands continued academic attention. Future research should explore the intertwined socio-economic, cultural and political dynamics reflected in personal narratives to enrich our understanding of this formative chapter in Bangladesh's past.

Note

1. This author's own translation from the memoir of Toaha, p.107 ("উর্দুর বিরোধিতা করলে ছাত্রদের কতল করা হবে", দেখুন, মোহাম্মদ তোয়াহা, স্মৃতিকথা, পৃ.১০৭).

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Ethical approval

This study is a philosophical-political and literature-based analysis of publicly available sources. It did not involve human participants, interviews, or the collection of personal data. Therefore, institutional ethics approval and informed consent were not required, and the study complies with international guidelines for research integrity.

Author contributions

CRedit: **Saleh Shahriar**: Conceptualization, Formal analysis, Methodology, Resources, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing.

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Data availability statement

Data sharing is not applicable to this article as no new data were created or analyzed in this study.

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